



**UNIVERSITY OF THE PHILIPPINES**

**Master of Science in Materials Science and Engineering**

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**Investigation of a-Si/SiO<sub>2</sub> antireflective coatings for InGaAs terahertz emitters**

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# CHAPTER 1

## INTRODUCTION

The development of devices which operate in the terahertz range has been a recent area of interest for researchers. The applications of terahertz waves include analysis of biological specimens[1], pharmaceuticals[2], and imaging[3] among others. The mechanisms by which these devices operate may include upconversion from the radio and mmWave range, or downconversion of photonic devices from the infrared region. An example of a device which utilizes downconversion is the terahertz photoconductive antenna (PCA), and there are already multiple demonstrations and even commercial PCA devices that utilize the 780 nm and 1550 nm wavelengths, which are supplied by Ti:sapphire and telecommunication fiber lasers respectively. A PCA consists of a semiconductor material where the terahertz generation or absorption occurs and two metal electrodes on the semiconductor surface separated by a few microns that forms the photoconductive gap[4]. When a femtosecond pulse from the laser illuminates the gap, carriers are generated in the semiconductor and swept by an electric field from the bias applied to the metal electrodes, and the movement of the carriers generates the terahertz wave.

One of the common semiconductor materials of choice for a PCA operating at the 1.55  $\mu\text{m}$  wavelength is low temperature (LT) grown indium gallium arsenide (InGaAs), which has a bandgap of  $E_g < 0.8 \text{ eV}$  and can be excited by common telecommunications wavelength lasers operating at 1550 nm[5]. Another common semiconductor material used for PCAs is LT gallium arsenide (GaAs), which has a bandgap of  $E_g < 1.42 \text{ eV}$  and is operated at a much shorter wavelength of 780 nm. However, when a bare PCA is illuminated by a laser there are significant reflection losses due to the high refractive index of the material[6]. Adding an antireflective coating to the PCA can increase the efficiency of the device by reducing the amount of light reflected by the

film. The challenge lies in the design of a suitable antireflective coating for the aforementioned wavelengths.

### **1.1 Significance of the study**

The development of terahertz (THz) PCAs which operate efficiently at commonly used wavelengths holds great potential for integrating THz technology with existing optical systems. By enhancing the efficiency of THz generation, this study contributes to the advancement of THz time domain spectroscopy (TDS) systems, which have diverse applications in fields such as biology, imaging, and pharmaceuticals. The Semiconductors group of the Condensed Matter Physics Laboratory in UP Diliman is able to grow LT-InGaAs and LT-InGaAs layers via molecular beam epitaxy (MBE), fabricate them into PCAs via photolithography, and study them using 1550 nm and 780 nm wavelength lasers. However, the PCAs being developed lack antireflective coatings optimized for their operating wavelengths. By integrating an antireflective coating (ARC) stack composed of a-Si and SiO<sub>2</sub>, two materials commonly used for CMOS processing, this study aims to address these problems, improving the THz intensity generated by the PCA and its overall performance. The findings could pave the way for more efficient THz devices, enhancing capabilities in scientific research, medical diagnostics, and industrial processes.

### **1.2 Objectives of the study**

The main objective of this study is to investigate the feasibility of using a-Si and SiO<sub>2</sub> thin films to create an antireflective coating which can be used for LT-InGaAs PCAs. Specifically, this will require the following objectives:

- to identify the optical properties of a-Si and SiO<sub>2</sub> thin films deposited using electron beam evaporation,
- to design an antireflective coating utilizing a-Si and SiO<sub>2</sub> optimized for the wavelengths at which LT-InGaAs and LT-GaAs THz PCAs can be operated, and

- to evaluate the reflectivity of the fabricated a-Si/SiO<sub>2</sub> antireflective coating at the relevant wavelengths.

### **1.3 Scope and limitations of the study**

The study will only cover the investigation of an amorphous silicon (a-Si) and SiO<sub>2</sub> ARC for LT-InGaAs and LT-GaAsTHz PCA applications. As such, the study will not investigate the growth of the LT-InGaAs and LT-GaAs film using MBE and will also be limited to electron beam evaporation as the deposition method for the a-Si/SiO<sub>2</sub>. The characterization is also limited to the evaluation of the reflectivity of the designed films and will not include implementations of the developed system.

## CHAPTER 2

### REVIEW OF RELATED LITERATURE

#### 2.1 Terahertz photoconductive antenna

The range of frequencies between microwave and infrared in the electromagnetic spectrum is known as the THz range. It was also called the THz gap in the past due to the difficulty of finding emitters and detectors which worked in this frequency range[7]. THz radiation is non-ionizing and can penetrate through organic material such as plastic and clothing, thus it has potential use in biological characterization[1], detection of contraband materials[8], and chemical identification[9]. Some substances have specific THz absorption spectra which can be used to identify their composition, as shown in Figure 2.1. The interaction amongst the bonds and forces in the molecules result in vibrational modes visible in the THz region[8]. On the other hand, THz reflection can be used to detect concealed objects when the concealing material is transparent to THz radiation as in refthrough, as the case for dielectrics such as clothing[10]. A common setup for some of these applications involves THz TDS.

In THz TDS, a THz pulse is generated using a PCA. The shape of the electrodes influences the pattern of the THz radiation generated by the PCA. Dipole and bowtie

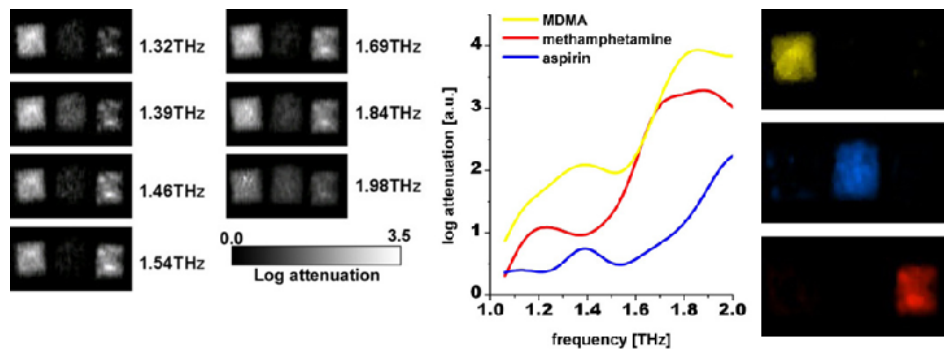


Figure 2.1: THz identification of MDMA, methamphetamine, and aspirin through a paper envelope. The substances are differentiated using their THz spectra[8]

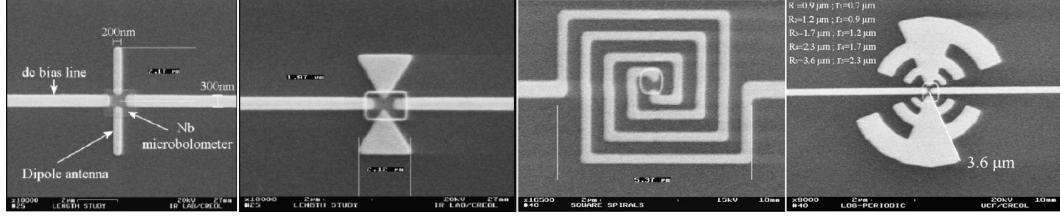


Figure 2.2: Commonly used THz PCA geometries; from left to right: dipole, bowtie, spiral, and log-spiral[11]

patterns demonstrate higher polarization ratios compared to spiral antennas while spiral and log-spiral antennas have a higher calculated radiation efficiency compared to bowtie and dipole antennas[11]. The shapes of the antennas are presented in Figure 2.2.

The emission mechanism for the PCA is as follows: the photoconductive material between the electrodes is illuminated with a femtosecond laser pulse, which generates photocarriers that are swept by an electric field applied to the electrodes of the PCA[4], [5]. The transient current  $i_{PC}(t)$  resulting from the moving carriers generates electromagnetic radiation according to Maxwell's equations, with the intensity of the electric field component of the THz wave radiated by a dipole antenna expressed by Equation 2.1

$$E_{THz}(r, \theta, t) = \frac{l_e}{4\pi\epsilon c^2 r} \frac{\partial i_{PC}(t)}{\partial t} \sin(\theta) \quad (2.1)$$

where  $l_e$  is the antenna length,  $\epsilon$  the permittivity,  $c$  the speed of light,  $r$  the distance from the dipole, and  $\theta$  the angle relative to the dipole axis[4].

The transient current density term  $i_{PC}(t)$  is proportional to the convolution integral of the carrier density  $n(t)$  and electron velocity  $v_e(t)$  as shown in Equation 2.2[4].

$$i_{PC}(t) \propto P_{pulse}(t) \otimes (n(t) v_e(t)). \quad (2.2)$$

The carrier density is described by

$$\frac{dn}{dt} = \eta \frac{P_{pulse}(t)}{h\nu} - \frac{n}{\tau_c} \quad (2.3)$$

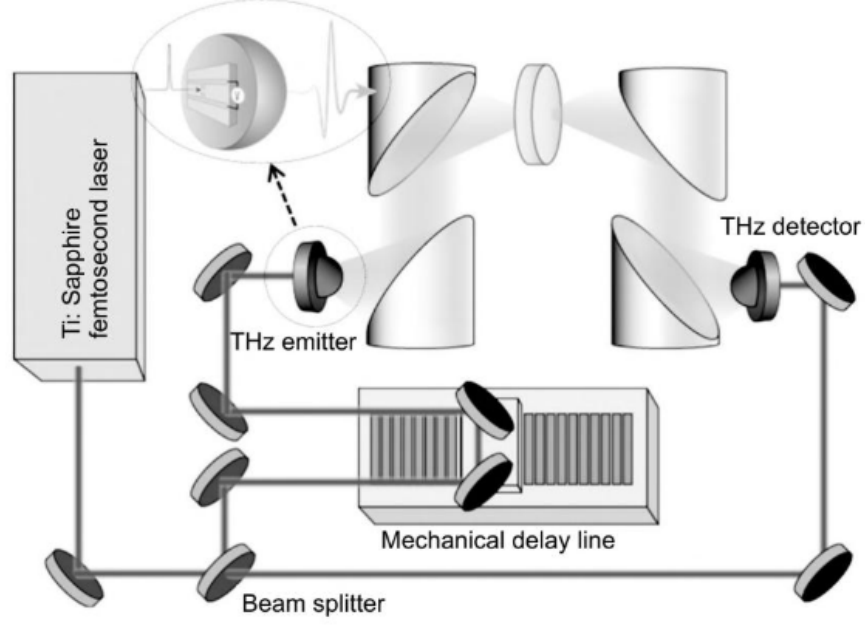


Figure 2.3: Schematic of a THz TDS setup with a femtosecond laser and two photoconductive antennas[4]

and using a 1D Drude-Lorentz model, the electron velocity by

$$\frac{dv_e}{dt} = -\frac{v_e}{\tau_s} + \frac{e}{m^*}E \quad (2.4)$$

where  $\eta$  is the absorption efficiency,  $P_{\text{pulse}}(t)$  the ultrashort laser pulse power considered over time,  $\tau_c$ ,  $\tau_s$ , and  $m^*$  the carrier lifetime, momentum relaxation time, electron effective mass respectively, and  $E$  the local electric field[4].

A photoconductive antenna is also used to detect THz radiation, with the incoming THz pulse focused together with a femtosecond pulse split from the same source at the gap of the antenna. As the femtosecond probe pulse arrives at the gap, carriers are excited and then accelerated proportionally by the electric field provided by the incoming THz pulse[5]. The difference of the probe pulse and the THz pulse provides a measurement in the time domain for the transient of the THz pulse. A schematic of a complete THz TDS system with emitter and detector is shown in Figure 2.3.

## 2.2 Low temperature grown InGaAs

From the previously discussed equations, the performance of the THz TDS system depends on multiple factors such as the properties of the femtosecond laser pulse and the quality of the photoconductive material. Modification of the photoconductive material is done to achieve short electron-hole recombination times, high carrier mobilities, and high breakdown electric fields, which all contribute to an increase in the intensity of generated THz radiation[12].

Some of the photoconductive materials used for THz TDS systems include LT grown GaAs and InGaAs[13], [14], [15]. LT-GaAs is grown via molecular beam epitaxy at 200 °C to 300 °C instead of the usual growth temperature around 600 °C[16]. The growth of GaAs and related compounds at relatively low temperatures and slower rates in molecular beam epitaxy compared to other epitaxial techniques result in mechanisms which are dominated by surface kinetics and surface chemistry[17]. MBE growth can be divided into two stages: the initial stage involving processes such as the chemisorption of molecules, their migration across the surface, and bond formation; and the subsequent stage which involves thermodynamic interaction and redistribution in the surface regions to form the crystal[17]. The molecular beam which supplies the material is produced by evaporation or sublimation of high-purity solid sources at elevated temperatures in ultra-high vacuum, allowing the molecules to reach the substrate without interacting. When the molecules arrive at the substrate, they are chemisorbed to the surface and can migrate to energetically favorable step edges or nucleated islands and form bonds, gather at contaminations to form defects or agglomerate with similar species, or desorb from the surface as shown in Figure 2.4[18], [19]. The thermodynamic interaction and redistribution of the layers close to the surface to form the final crystal configuration has been observed during the growth process of InGaAs using Auger electron and x-ray photoemission spectroscopy[20], [21].

The low growth temperature coupled with excess arsenic during the process creates a non-stoichiometric material with a high concentration of point defects in the form

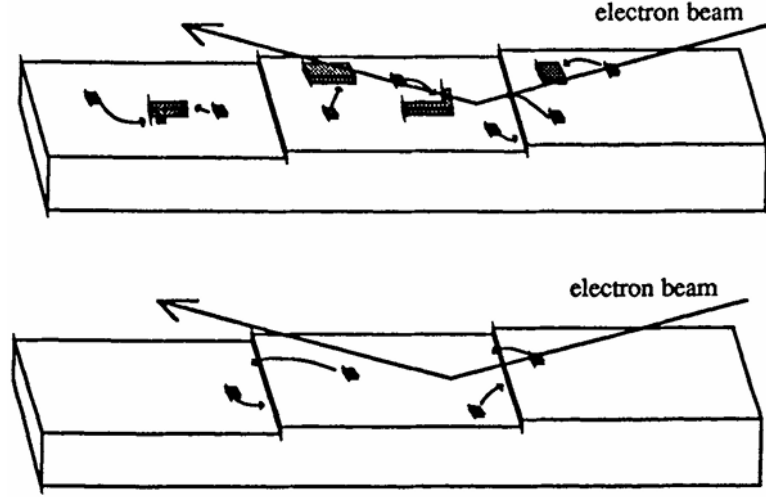


Figure 2.4: Kinetics of epitaxial growth observed using an electron beam. Molecules can form islands, migrate to step edges, or desorb from the surface.[17]

of As antisites  $\text{As}_{\text{Ga}}$  close to the center of the bandgap as shown in Figure 2.5 [22]. The  $\text{As}_{\text{Ga}}$  point defects can be found in the neutral  $\text{As}_{\text{Ga}}^0$  and charged  $\text{As}_{\text{Ga}}^+$  states, with reported concentrations of  $1 \times 10^{20}/\text{cm}^3$  and  $1 \times 10^{10}/\text{cm}^3$  respectively at a growth temperature of  $200^\circ\text{C}$ [23]. Close to the valence band, acceptor vacancies  $\text{V}_{\text{Ga}}$  form at equal concentration to  $\text{As}_{\text{Ga}}^+$ .  $\text{As}_{\text{Ga}}^+$  acts as an electron trap, and together with the other mid-bandgap states serve as a ready source of electrons that can be easily promoted to the conduction band, which results in a much larger carrier concentration in the conduction band compared to ordinary material which relies solely on band-to-band transitions[24]. Despite the high defect concentration of LT-GaAs, the material has been reported to have high carrier mobility of around  $200 \text{ cm}^2/(\text{V s})$ [24].

The partial substitution of Ga atoms by In in the GaAs structure results in the ternary alloy  $\text{In}_x\text{Ga}_{1-x}\text{As}$ . Controlling the bandgap and consequently absorption wavelength for InGaAs is done by changing the mole fractions of In and Ga as shown in Figure 2.6 [25]. The ratios of In and Ga are easily controlled by changing the fluxes of the corresponding sources during epitaxial growth.

A phase diagram for the surface reconstruction of  $\text{In}_x\text{Ga}_{(1-x)}\text{As}$  as a function of In composition on GaAs(100) and InAs(100) substrates is shown in Figure 2.7[26]. The gaps in the phase diagram indicate locations where the morphology of the surface is no longer uniform and flat enough to obtain data from scanning tunneling microscopy

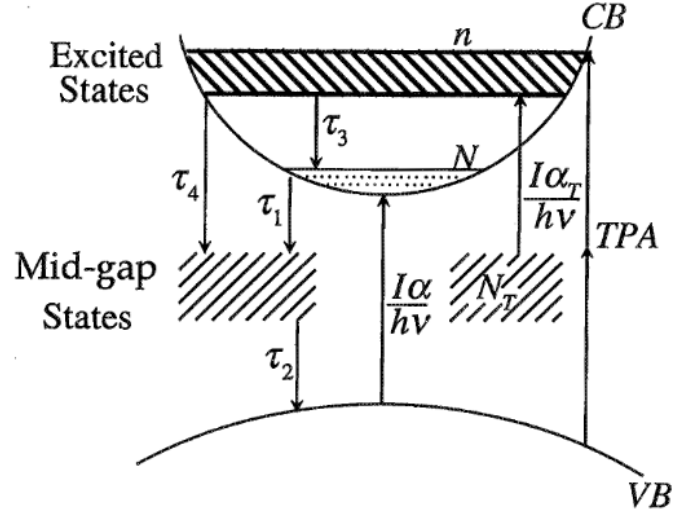


Figure 2.5: Energy level diagram of the defect states in LT-GaAs[24]

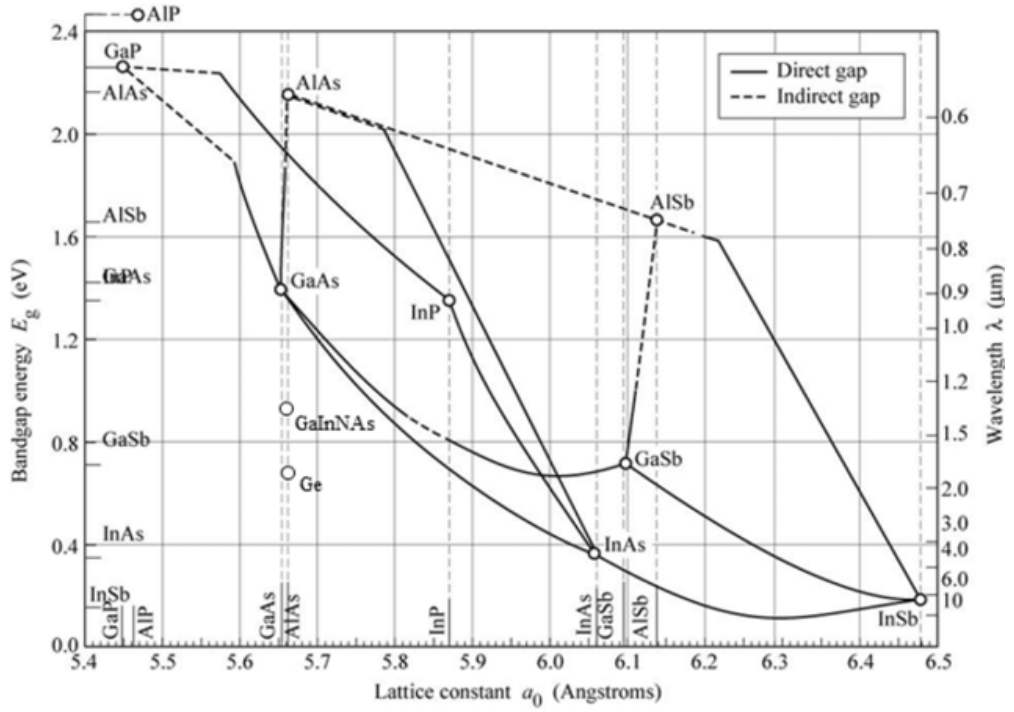


Figure 2.6: Bandgap versus lattice constant for various III-V compounds[25]

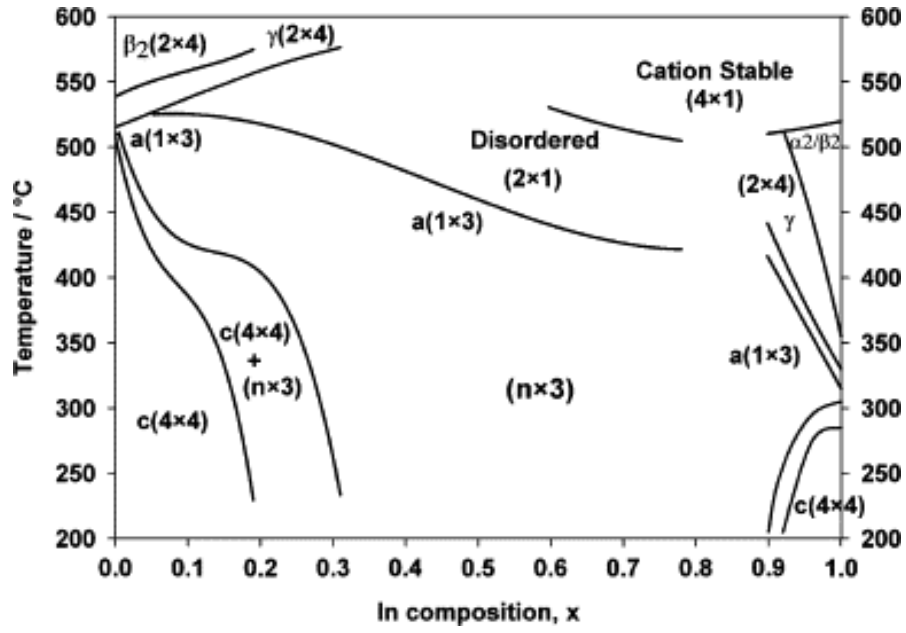


Figure 2.7: Phase diagram for the surface reconstruction of In<sub>x</sub>Ga<sub>(1-x)</sub>As using RHEED (STM) and reflective high energy electron diffraction (RHEED).

For InGaAs on GaAs(100) the system is compressively strained and becomes progressively rougher as the In fraction increases, while InGaAs grown on InAs(100) is tensile strained, thus the choice of substrate is also important during epitaxy. Based on Figure 2.6 InP is the most suitable substrate lattice matched to InGaAs operating at 1.55 μm, however InP is highly absorbing for THz radiation and has a relatively high refractive index which hinders efficient emission of THz radiation as shown in Figure 2.8[27].

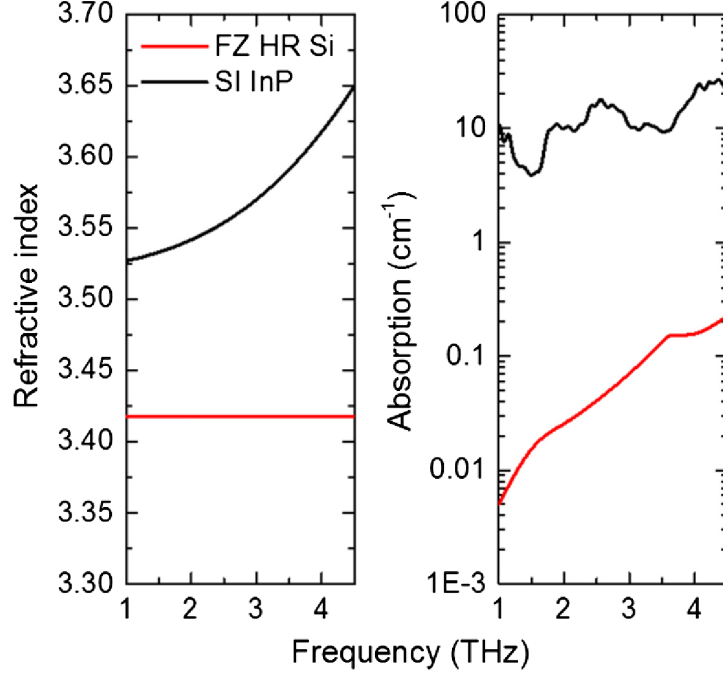


Figure 2.8: Refractive index and absorption coefficient of semi-insulating InP and float zone high resistivity Si in the THz range[4]

### 2.3 Distributed Bragg Reflector

Increasing the absorption of the photoconductive material can be done by reflecting unabsorbed light from the laser back into the material by means of a distributed Bragg reflector[28]. A DBR is composed of a stack of alternating layers of materials having different refractive indices. When an electromagnetic wave propagates across the boundary of two materials with differing refractive indices, partial reflection of the field occurs if the refractive index of the succeeding material is greater than that of the material before it. If the thickness of each layer is set to a quarter of the wavelength of interest, the reflection from each successive interface is shifted by half the wavelength and the collection of all reflected components interfere constructively[29].

An explanation of the distributed Bragg reflector can be obtained from the wave equation as given by

$$\frac{d^2 E}{dz^2} + \left\{ \frac{\omega^2}{c^2} [n_0 + n_1 \cos(2\beta_m z)] + j \frac{\omega}{c} [-n_0 i \gamma_0 + \gamma_1 \cos(2\beta_m z + \theta)] \right\} E = 0 \quad (2.5)$$

where the involved terms are  $\beta_0 = \frac{\omega}{c} n_0$  the phase constant of the unperturbed mode,

$g_0 = \gamma_0/2$  the field coefficient,  $g_1 = \gamma_1/2$  the perturbation in the field coefficient,  $\kappa = \frac{\omega}{c} \cdot \frac{n_1}{2} + j\frac{g_1}{2}$  the coupling coefficient, and  $2\beta_m = \frac{2\pi}{\Lambda}$  where  $\Lambda$  is the mechanical periodicity  $\lambda_B/2n_0$ . By using some approximations, Equation 2.5 can be reduced to the matrix equation

$$\begin{bmatrix} f'' \\ r'' \end{bmatrix} - p^2 \begin{bmatrix} f \\ r \end{bmatrix} = 0 \quad (2.6)$$

where  $p^2 = \kappa^2 + (g_0 - j\delta)^2$ . Returning to the example of the propagating electromagnetic wave  $E_+$  at  $z = -L/2$ , if the medium through which it propagates is periodic as shown in Figure 2.9, then a reverse wave  $r$  is generated which contributes to the reflected wave  $E_-$  at the same boundary. A portion of the propagating wave may reach the right boundary of the periodic structure at  $z = L/2$  and turn into a transmitted wave  $E_t$ . There is no reverse wave at the right boundary since the medium beyond does not have the properties to reflect the wave. When the field gain coefficient  $g_0 = 0$  (and also for  $g_1$ ), the coupling coefficient  $\kappa$  is a real number, and Equation 2.6 simplifies to the equation

$$(pL)^2 = (\kappa L)^2 - (\delta L)^2. \quad (2.7)$$

The power transmission and reflection coefficients at the band center are given by

$$\begin{aligned} R &= |S_{11}|^2 \approx [1 - 2e^{-2\kappa L}]^2 \\ T &= |S_{12}|^2 \approx 4e^{-2\kappa L} \end{aligned} \quad (2.8)$$

The region at  $-\kappa L < [\delta L = (\beta_0 - \beta_m)L] < \kappa L$  is known as the stop band of the DBR, since the wavelengths which satisfy this condition are heavily attenuated while propagating through the structure, as shown in the power transmission graph in Figure 2.10. The amplitudes of the propagating electric field decrease exponentially as shown in Figure 2.9. Some of the methods used to simulate the operation of DBRs include finite element analysis [31] and the transfer matrix method[32].

There are multiple material pairs that can be chosen for the DBR. A commonly

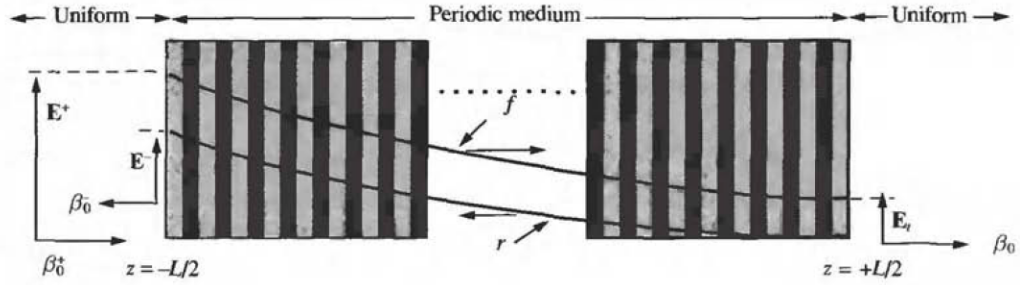


Figure 2.9: Geometry of a distributed Bragg reflector medium with a source of electromagnetic waves located on the left. The amplitude of  $\mathbf{E}$  decreases as it propagates through the structure[30].

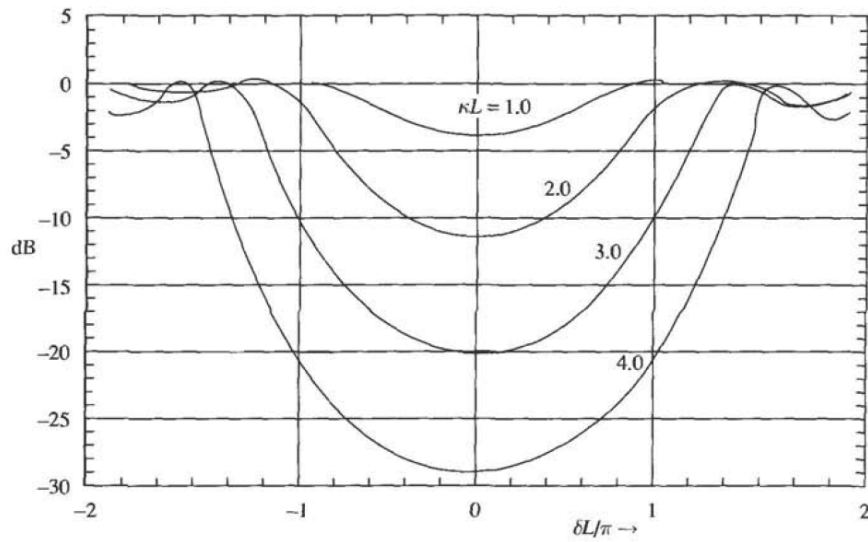


Figure 2.10: Relative power transmission of a DBR versus the detuning parameter  $\delta L / \pi$  for various coupling coefficient  $\kappa L$  values [4]

used material pair is AlAs/GaAs, which can be grown via MBE[33]. Other material systems which have been grown epitaxially for vertical cavity surface emitting lasers based on InP substrates operating at 1.55  $\mu\text{m}$  include InGaAsP/InP, AlGaAsSb/AlAsSb, and AlInGaAs/AlInAs, but they require a high number of mirror periods to achieve saturation and the cost of such a growth process would be impractical[34]. A DBR made of Si/SiO<sub>2</sub> is more economical to fabricate, with processes ranging from sputtering to electron beam deposition, but the challenge would now be the transfer of the film from its original growth substrate to the fabricated stack. A transfer process that would preserve the integrity of the film becomes necessary. HCl is known as a selective etchant for InP while leaving InGaAs intact and has been used to isolate InGaAs from sacrificial InP layers with the resulting thin films maintaining an acceptable level of surface roughness and quality[35].

RF magnetron sputtering has been used to deposit a-Si and SiO<sub>2</sub> layers for different applications such as nanolaminate structures[36], superlattices[37], and DBRs for VCSELs[38]. Sputtering utilizes collisions between energized particles of the working gas and the atoms on the cathode target to supply the material to be deposited. Sputtering is done at vacuum pressures to reduce unwanted collisions between gas particles [39]. The working gas is commonly argon due to its inertness and availability.

In DC diode sputtering a discharge voltage  $V_D$  is applied to ionize the working gas, as shown in Figure 2.11a. The applied  $V_D$  must be greater than the breakdown voltage  $V_B$  of the gas, in order to ionize the electrons from the gas particles and create plasma via an avalanche effect. DC diode sputtering works well when the target is conductive and metallic, but when the target is insulating due to its inherent properties or impurities then an interfering charge begins to build up. This build-up is avoided by the use of an AC voltage cycled at extremely high or radio frequency (RF). DC sputtering is also limited by the lifespan of the electrons in the vicinity of the target. Adding a static magnetic field  $B$  to confine the ions as shown in Figure 2.11b solves this problem, as it

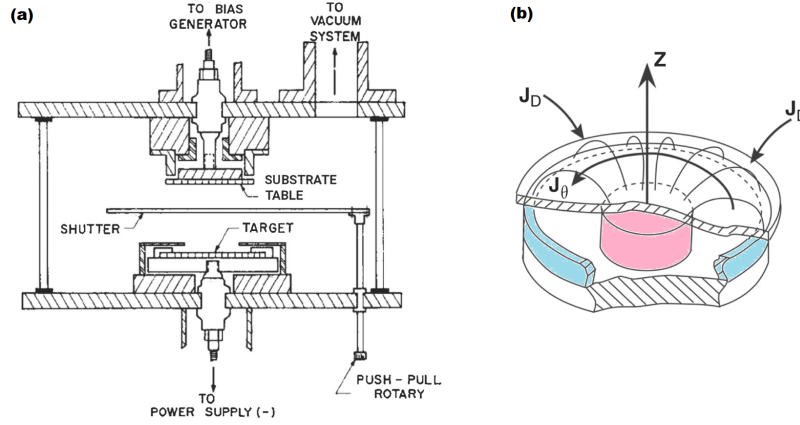


Figure 2.11: Schematics of a magnetron sputtering system (a) with cathode target (b). The plasma is confined by the magnetic field in a toroidal pattern[4].

is easier to accelerate a charged ion  $q$  with velocity  $\mathbf{v}$  according to the Lorentz equation:

$$\mathbf{F} = q(\mathbf{E} + \mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{B}) \quad (2.9)$$

where  $\mathbf{E}$  is the electric field and  $\mathbf{F}$  is the force experienced by the particle. Compound films can be formed when a reactive gas such as  $\text{O}_2$  is included with the working gas, as a chemical reaction between the reactive gas and sputtered atoms can occur mostly at the surface of the substrate. The whole process is thus called reactive radio frequency magnetron sputtering.

## 2.4 Electromagnetic Waves in Dielectric Materials

The propagation of electromagnetic waves through dielectric materials can be described using the Fresnel equations, which can be derived from the boundary conditions that constrain the electric and magnetic field components arising as a direct result of Maxwell's equations. Suppose incident light approaches a boundary between two dielectric materials with refractive indices  $n_1$  and  $n_2$  as shown in Figure 2.12. The first case shows s-polarized light, where the electric field is perpendicular to the plane of incidence, while the second case shows p-polarized light, where the electric field is parallel to the plane of incidence. The incident and reflected angles are equal  $\theta_i = \theta_r$ , and the transmitted angle is given by Snell's law  $n_1 \sin \theta_i = n_2 \sin \theta_t$ . The boundary conditions

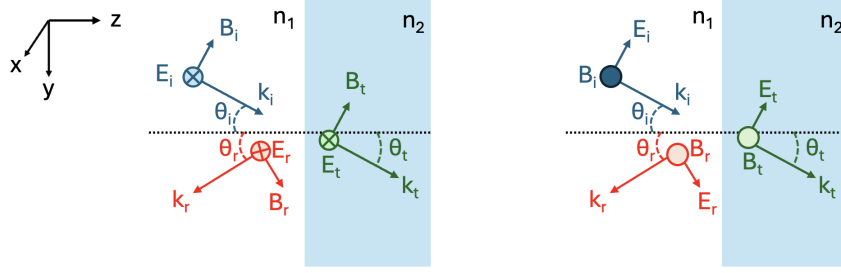


Figure 2.12: Diagram of polarized light at two interfaces. The left image shows the case for s-polarized light, with the electric field pointing into the page. For p-polarized light on the right the magnetic field points outside of the page.

require that the components of the electric and magnetic fields be continuous, thus for s-polarized light, the electric fields are given by  $E_i + E_r = E_t$  or  $1 + r = t$ , where  $r$  and  $t$  are the reflected and transmitted amplitudes and the incident amplitude is normalized to 1. The y-component of the magnetic field is given by  $H_i \cos \theta_i - H_r \cos \theta_r = H_t \cos \theta_t$ , which can be rewritten as  $n_1 \cos \theta_i (1 - r) = n_2 \cos \theta_t t$  using the relation  $H = nE/c$ . Solving for  $r$  gives

$$r_s = \frac{n_1 \cos \theta_i - n_2 \cos \theta_t}{n_1 \cos \theta_i + n_2 \cos \theta_t} \quad (2.10)$$

while solving for  $t$  gives

$$t_s = \frac{2n_1 \cos \theta_i}{n_1 \cos \theta_i + n_2 \cos \theta_t}. \quad (2.11)$$

For p-polarized light, the magnetic fields are given by  $H_i + H_r = H_t$  or  $n_1(1 + r) = n_2 t$ , thus the electric fields are given by  $E_i \cos \theta_i - E_r \cos \theta_r = E_t \cos \theta_t$ , which can be rewritten as  $n_1(1 - r) \cos \theta_i = n_2 t \cos \theta_t$ . Solving for  $r$  gives

$$r_p = \frac{n_2 \cos \theta_i - n_1 \cos \theta_t}{n_2 \cos \theta_i + n_1 \cos \theta_t} \quad (2.12)$$

while solving for  $t$  gives

$$t_p = \frac{2n_1 \cos \theta_i}{n_2 \cos \theta_i + n_1 \cos \theta_t}. \quad (2.13)$$

## 2.5 Transfer Matrix Method

At the boundary between two dielectric materials, the electric field amplitudes of the incident, reflected, and transmitted waves can be related using a transfer matrix. In the schematic shown in Figure 2.13a, a wave with amplitude  $E_1^+$  is moving to the right, and another wave with amplitude  $E_1^-$  is moving to the left. For the other side of the boundary, the amplitudes are  $E_2^+$  and  $E_2^-$ . The fields can be characterized using two  $2 \times 1$  matrices, one for each side of the boundary, and a  $2 \times 2$  interface matrix  $\mathbf{D}$  as shown:

$$\begin{bmatrix} E_1^+ \\ E_1^- \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} D_{12} & D_{21} \\ D_{12} & D_{21} \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} E_2^+ \\ E_2^- \end{bmatrix} \quad (2.14)$$

The values of the matrix elements  $D_{ij}$  can be obtained from inspecting Figure 2.13a. The subscripts  $i$  and  $j$  refer to the direction of the wave propagation, with  $t_{12}$  signifying transmission from medium 1 to medium 2, and  $r_{12}$  signifying reflection from medium 1 to medium 2. The fields are thus given by

$$E_2^+ = t_{12}E_1^+ + r_{21}E_2^- \quad (2.15)$$

$$E_1^- = r_{12}E_1^+ + t_{21}E_2^- \quad (2.16)$$

which can be rearranged to

$$E_1^+ = \frac{E_2^+ - r_{21}E_2^-}{t_{12}} \quad (2.17)$$

$$E_1^- = \frac{r_{12}}{t_{12}} (E_2^+ - r_{21}E_2^-) + t_{21}E_2^- \quad (2.18)$$

Considering that the reflection coefficient is  $r = (n_1 - n_2) / (n_1 + n_2)$  then  $r_{12} = -r_{21}$ . For the transmission coefficient  $t = 2n_1 / (n_1 + n_2)$ , and  $t_{12} = n_2 t_{21} / n_1$ . Substituting these relations into Equation 2.17 and Equation 2.18 with the assumption that  $R+T = 1$  yields the matrix equation for the interface  $\mathbf{D}$

$$\begin{bmatrix} E_1^+ \\ E_1^- \end{bmatrix} = \frac{1}{t_{12}} \begin{bmatrix} 1 & r_{12} \\ r_{12} & 1 \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} E_2^+ \\ E_2^- \end{bmatrix} \quad (2.19)$$

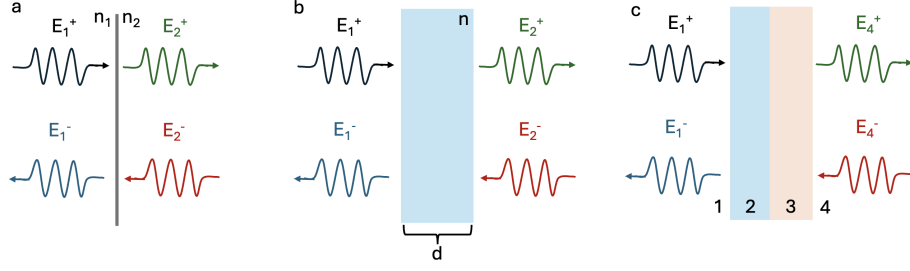


Figure 2.13: Propagation of waves at an interface (a), through a layer with refractive index  $n$  and thickness  $d$  (b), and through a multilayer system (c).

The propagation matrix  $\mathbf{P}$  for a layer of thickness  $d$  and refractive index  $n$  can be obtained by considering the geometry of the waves in Figure 2.13b, where a layer with refractive index  $n$  and thickness  $d$  has been inserted between the two waves. The wave moving to the right varies as  $E^+ = E_0 e^{-j(k_y y + k_z z - \omega t)}$ , and the difference between the two waves at the left and right boundaries is given by  $E_2^+ = E_1^+ e^{jkz \cos \theta}$  with the reverse given by  $E_2^- = E_1^- e^{-jkz \cos \theta}$ . The propagation matrix is thus given by

$$\begin{bmatrix} E_1^+ \\ E_1^- \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} e^{jkd \cos \theta} & 0 \\ 0 & e^{-jkd \cos \theta} \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} E_2^+ \\ E_2^- \end{bmatrix} \quad (2.20)$$

where  $k = 2\pi n/\lambda$  is the wavenumber in the medium. This analysis can be extended to a two layer system by multiplying the interface and propagation matrices while considering the order of the layers. Starting from the rightmost boundary as shown in Figure 2.13c, the fields on both sides are related using the interface matrix by  $\mathbf{E}_{3R} = \mathbf{D}_{34} \mathbf{E}_4$ , where  $3R$  is the field at the right side of layer 3. The fields at the left side of layer 3 are related to the right side by the propagation matrix  $\mathbf{E}_{3L} = \mathbf{P}_3 \mathbf{E}_{3R}$ , which in turn can be related using another interface matrix to the field across the relevant boundary. This results in the following matrix equation relating the fields at the leftmost region to the rightmost region:

$$\mathbf{M} = \mathbf{D}_{12} \mathbf{P}_2 \mathbf{D}_{23} \mathbf{P}_3 \mathbf{D}_{34} \quad (2.21)$$

such that

$$\begin{bmatrix} E_1^+ \\ E_1^- \end{bmatrix} = \mathbf{M} \begin{bmatrix} E_4^+ \\ E_4^- \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} M_{11} & M_{12} \\ M_{21} & M_{22} \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} E_4^+ \\ E_4^- \end{bmatrix}. \quad (2.22)$$

This method allows the analysis of any multilayer system using matrix multiplication of the component interface  $\mathbf{D}$  and propagation  $\mathbf{P}$  matrices. The reflection coefficient  $r$  for a multilayer structure is simply

$$r = \frac{M_{21}}{M_{11}} \quad (2.23)$$

since  $t = 1/M_{11}$  and  $r = M_{21}/M_{11}$ .

## 2.6 Envelope method for refractive index

## CHAPTER 3

### METHODOLOGY

#### 3.1 Initial growth of a-Si and SiO<sub>2</sub> thin films via electron beam evaporation

Glass slides and Si wafers were used as substrates for the initial growth via electron beam evaporation of a-Si and SiO<sub>2</sub> thin films respectively. The substrates were cleaned by sonication in acetone, isopropanol, and deionized water for 5 minutes each, after which they were blow-dried with nitrogen gas. The substrates were then loaded into the ULVAC electron beam evaporation chamber, where a base pressure of  $4.5 \times 10^{-4}$  Pa was achieved before actual deposition. Deposition was carried out at room temperature, and the nominal deposition rates and thicknesses of the films were monitored using a quartz crystal microbalance (QCM) with the input values in Table 3.1.

#### 3.2 Characterization of a-Si and SiO<sub>2</sub> thin films

After unloading the samples from the chamber, the thicknesses of the films were measured using x-ray reflectivity (XRR) with a Malvern Panalytical Empyrean x-ray diffractometer. Curve fitting was performed on selected samples to obtain the densities and interface roughness of the films. The refractive index of the a-Si film was determined using Swanepoel's method via UV-Vis spectroscopy with a Shimadzu UV-Vis spectrophotometer while the refractive index of the SiO<sub>2</sub> film was identified using the interference method via the reflectance spectroscopy setup as shown in Figure 3.1. The measured refractive indices of the a-Si and SiO<sub>2</sub> films were used for the design of the a-Si/SiO<sub>2</sub> ARC stack.

|                  | z-factor | $\rho$ g/cm <sup>3</sup> |
|------------------|----------|--------------------------|
| Si               | 0.712    | 2.32                     |
| SiO <sub>2</sub> | 1        | 2.65                     |

Table 3.1: QCM inputs

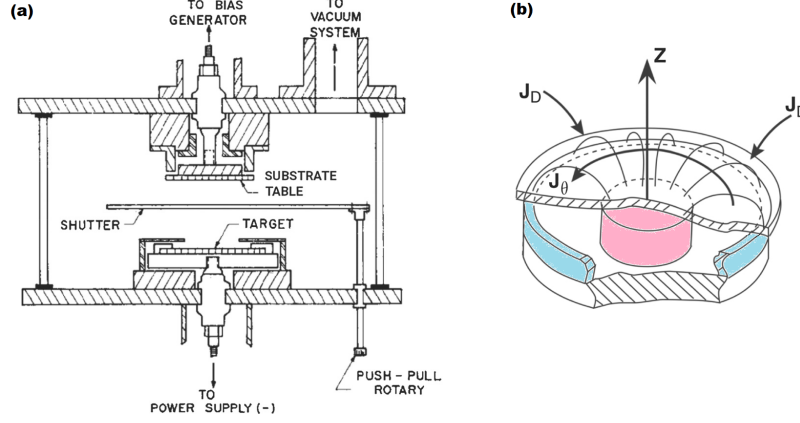


Figure 3.1: Schematics of a magnetron sputtering system (a) with cathode target (b). The plasma is confined by the magnetic field in a toroidal pattern[4].

### 3.3 Simulation and growth of a-Si/SiO<sub>2</sub> antireflective coatings

A transfer matrix method (TMM) implementation in Python was used to calculate the optimal thicknesses of the Si and SiO<sub>2</sub> layers for the antireflective coating stack. The refractive indices of the a-Si and SiO<sub>2</sub> layers used for the simulation were obtained from the previous section. The optimal thicknesses of the layers were calculated to minimize the reflectance at 1550 nm and 780 nm, which are the wavelengths of the lasers which can be used in the THz-TDS spectroscopy system. The program iterated over a range of thicknesses for each layer while calculating the reflectance of the stack, selecting the thicknesses that resulted in the lowest reflectance at the target wavelengths. The thicknesses obtained from the simulation were then used for the growth of the a-Si/SiO<sub>2</sub> ARC on bare wafers via electron beam evaporation. The reflectance of the samples with the antireflective coating was measured via reflectance spectroscopy and compared to the simulated reflectance to verify the accuracy of the simulation and growth process.

# CHAPTER 4

## RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

### 4.1 Thicknesses and densities of a-Si and SiO<sub>2</sub> thin films

Figure 4.1 and Figure 4.2 show the XRR measurements of various a-Si films grown on glass substrates and SiO<sub>2</sub> films grown on Si(100) substrates respectively with varying thicknesses according to the QCM readings across different growth runs. From the graphs of the intensity the  $2\theta$  range at which the detector can count the reflected x-rays generally ranges from  $0.3^\circ$  to  $2.0^\circ$ . The measured thicknesses of the a-Si film based on XRR are summarized in Table 4.1, while for SiO<sub>2</sub> the results are summarized in Table 4.2. No thickness data could be obtained from XRR for films which were thicker than  $1.52 \text{ k}\text{\AA}$  for a-Si and  $1.369 \text{ k}\text{\AA}$  for SiO<sub>2</sub>.

Figure 4.5, Figure 4.6, Figure 4.7 and Figure 4.8 show the simulated curves using the XRR software for selected a-Si films on glass substrates and SiO<sub>2</sub> films on Si. The values of thickness, interface roughness and densities obtained by fitting the curve are summarized in Table 4.3.

Linear regression of the measured thicknesses versus the QCM readings for a-Si as shown in Figure 4.3 yields the equation

| QCM (k $\text{\AA}$ ) | Direct (nm) | Fourier (nm) |
|-----------------------|-------------|--------------|
| 0.035                 | 7.822       | 6.90         |
| 0.069                 | 14.077      | 13.80        |
| 0.104                 | 21.290      | 21.20        |
| 0.138                 | 27.529      | 27.50        |
| 1.270                 | 214.620     | 213.15       |
| 1.520                 | 259.840     | 259.20       |

Table 4.1: a-Si thicknesses measured using the QCM, direct fringe calculation and Fourier method from the XRR spectra

| QCM (kÅ) | Direct (nm) | Fourier (nm) |
|----------|-------------|--------------|
| 0.525    | 104.6       | 103.9        |
| 0.884    | 165.1       | 163.2        |
| 1.050    | 206.6       | 204.7        |
| 1.369    | 272.3       | 270.1        |

Table 4.2: SiO<sub>2</sub> thicknesses measured using the QCM, direct fringe calculation and Fourier method from the XRR spectra

|                           | Thickness (nm) | Roughness (nm) | Density (g/cm <sup>3</sup> ) |
|---------------------------|----------------|----------------|------------------------------|
| 21.20 nm a-Si             | 21.9115        | 0.7047         | 1.80726                      |
| 27.50 nm a-Si             | 28.4339        | 0.8008         | 1.75748                      |
| 103.9 nm SiO <sub>2</sub> | 104.5311       | 0.3626         | 1.69738                      |
| 204.7 nm SiO <sub>2</sub> | 203.8994       | 0.741          | 2.04566                      |

Table 4.3: Thickness, roughness and densities calculated from XRR curve fitting

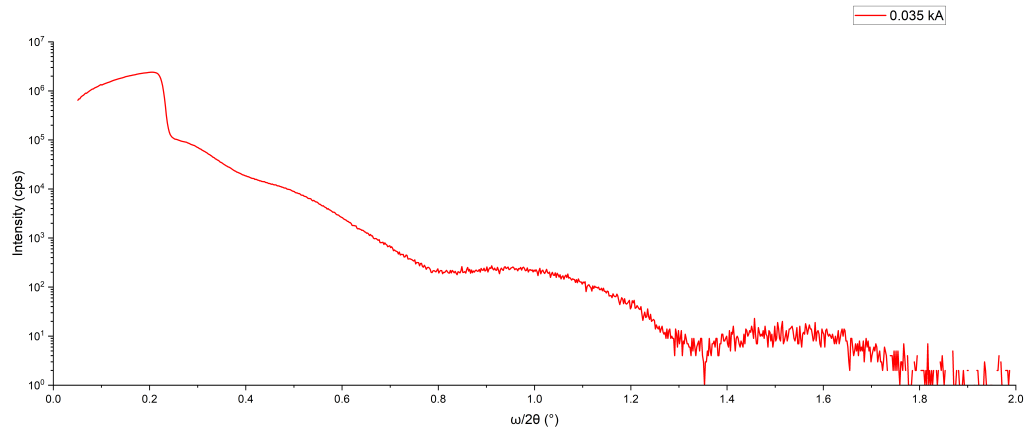
$$y = 168.03x + 3.0403 \quad (4.1)$$

with  $R^2 = 0.9999$ , where  $y$  is the measured XRR thickness in nm and  $x$  is the QCM reading in kÅ. Similarly, linear regression of the measured XRR thickness and the QCM values for SiO<sub>2</sub> as shown in Figure 4.4 yields the following equation with  $R^2 = 0.9941$ :

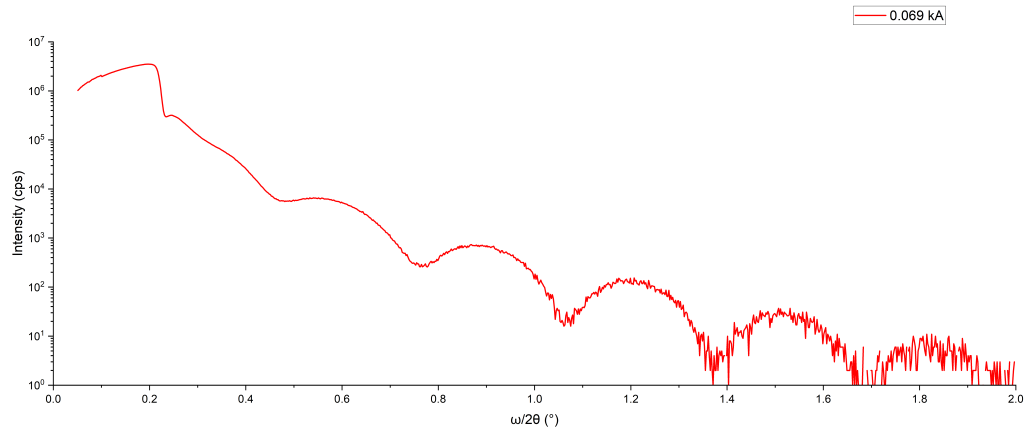
$$y = 198.52x - 4.5056 \quad (4.2)$$

The initial comparison of the QCM readings and the measured thicknesses during XRR indicate that the QCM readings during deposition generally underestimate the actual thicknesses of the films. This underestimation is likely due to the mismatch in densities used as input for the QCM as shown in Table 3.1 and the actual densities of the evaporated film as shown in Table 4.3. The thicknesses of the films as obtained by curve fitting generally agree with the direct and Fourier method of analysis for the Kiessig fringes. The low interface roughness of the films imply that electron beam evaporation is an effective method to produce uniform films, albeit with much lower densities than the bulk material. This discrepancy may be caused by the increased porosity of the film

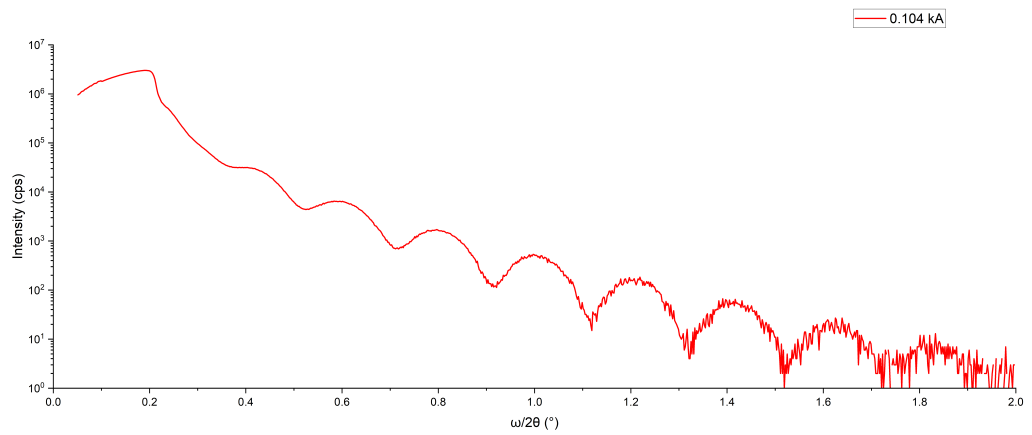
Nevertheless, the results of the regression analysis indicate that the QCM readings scale linearly with the actual thicknesses of the films as measured by XRR. The high  $R^2$  values suggest that the QCM is a reliable tool for monitoring film thickness during deposition as long as the linear relationship is considered, and that the linear relationships obtained in this study can be used to calibrate the QCM readings for future depositions. The lower  $R^2$  value in the regression for  $\text{SiO}_2$  is attributed to the variation in the deposition rate during the growth of the  $\text{SiO}_2$  films, which is caused by the difficulty in maintaining a stable deposition rate for  $\text{SiO}_2$  due to its low thermal conductivity and tendency to sublime instead of melting into a uniform liquid pool during heating by the electron beam as is the case for other materials.



(a) 0.035 kÅ a-Si thin film

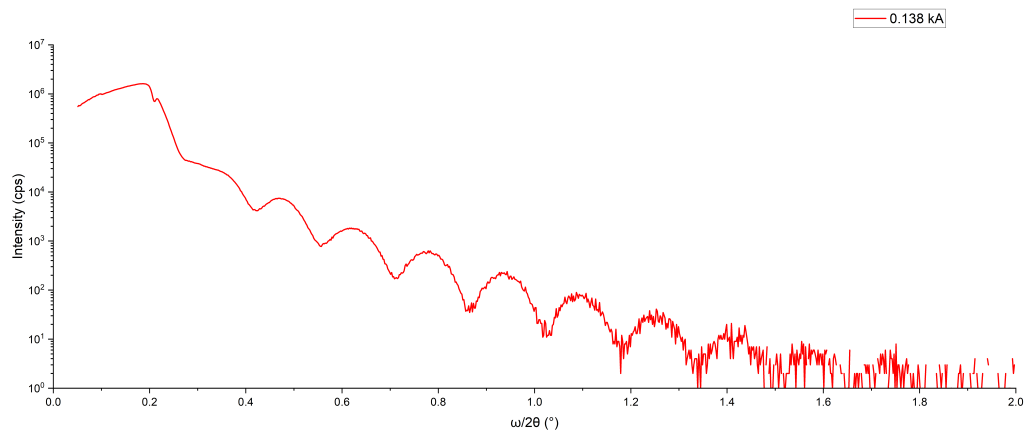


(b) 0.069 kÅ a-Si thin film

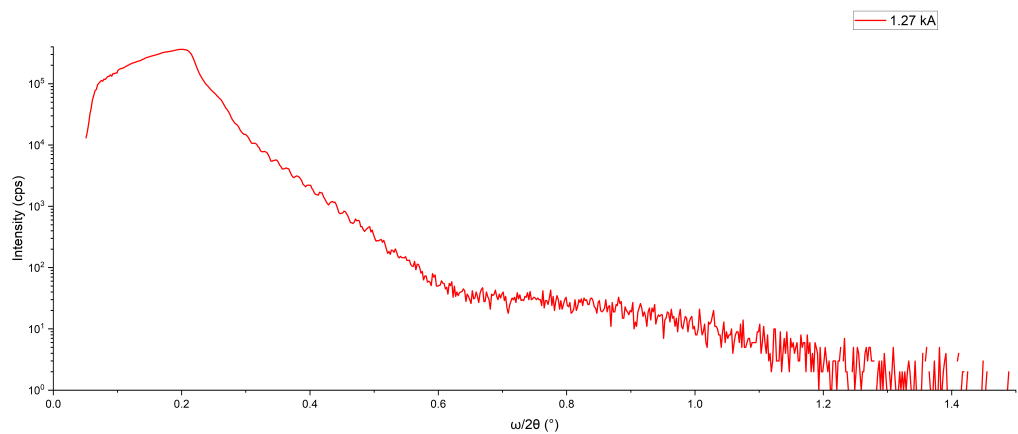


(c) 0.104 kÅ a-Si thin film

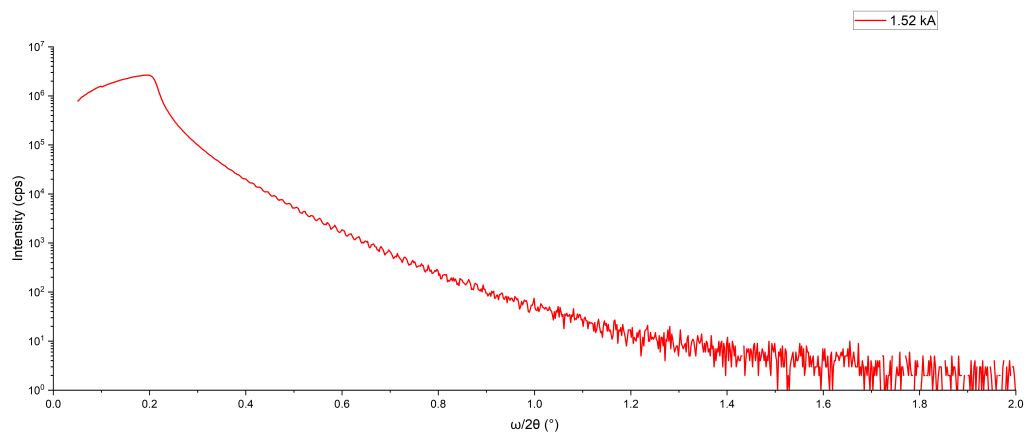
Figure 4.1: XRR measurements of a-Si thin films with varying QCM thicknesses



(d) 0.138 kÅ a-Si thin film

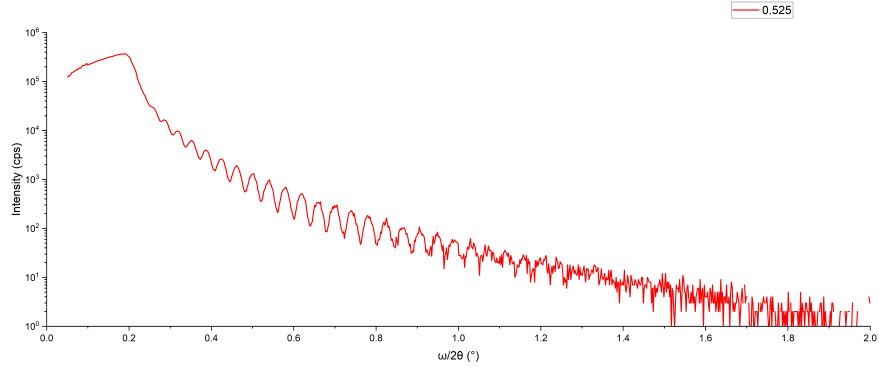


(e) 1.270 kÅ a-Si thin film

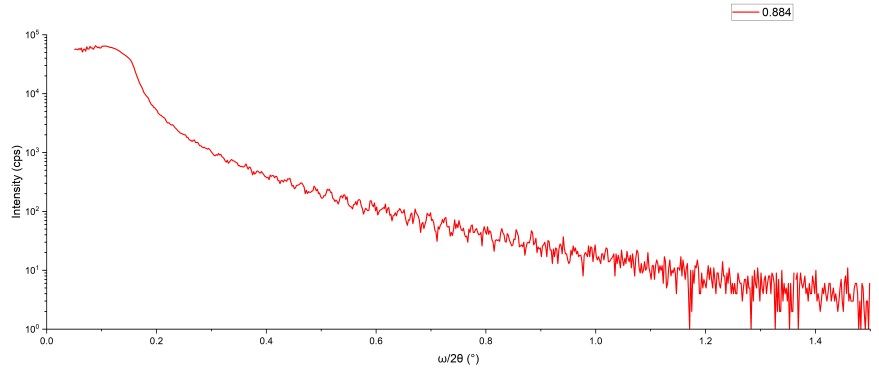


(f) 1.520 kÅ a-Si thin film

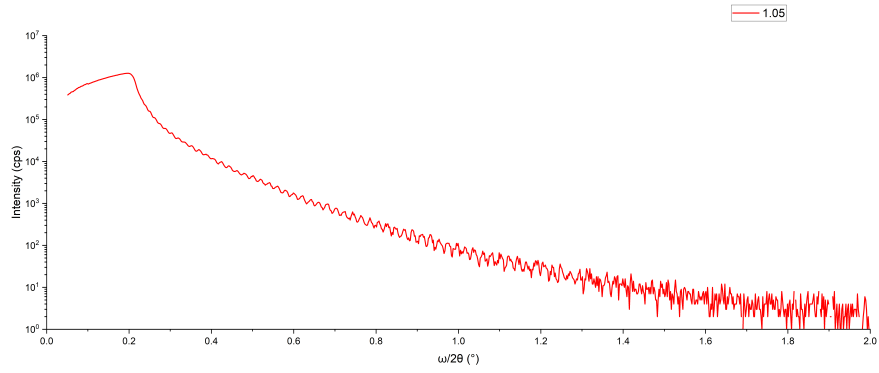
Figure 4.1: XRR measurements of a-Si thin films with varying QCM thicknesses, continued



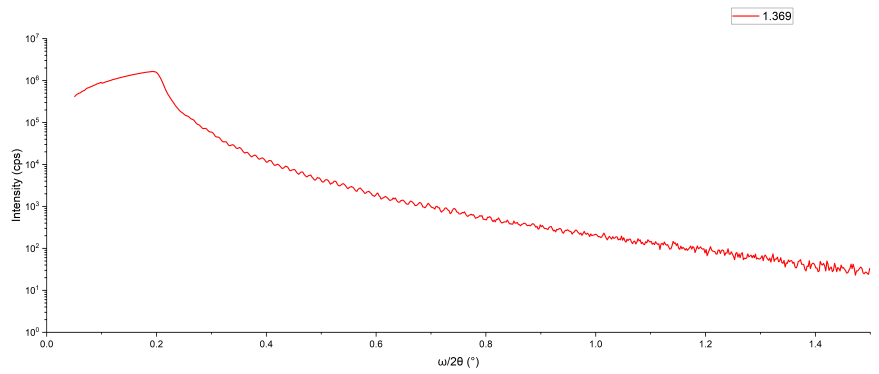
(a) 0.525 kÅ SiO<sub>2</sub> thin film



(b) 0.884 kÅ SiO<sub>2</sub> thin film



(c) 1.050 kÅ SiO<sub>2</sub> thin film



(d) 1.369 kÅ SiO<sub>2</sub> thin film

Figure 4.2: XRR measurements of SiO<sub>2</sub> thin films with varying QCM thicknesses

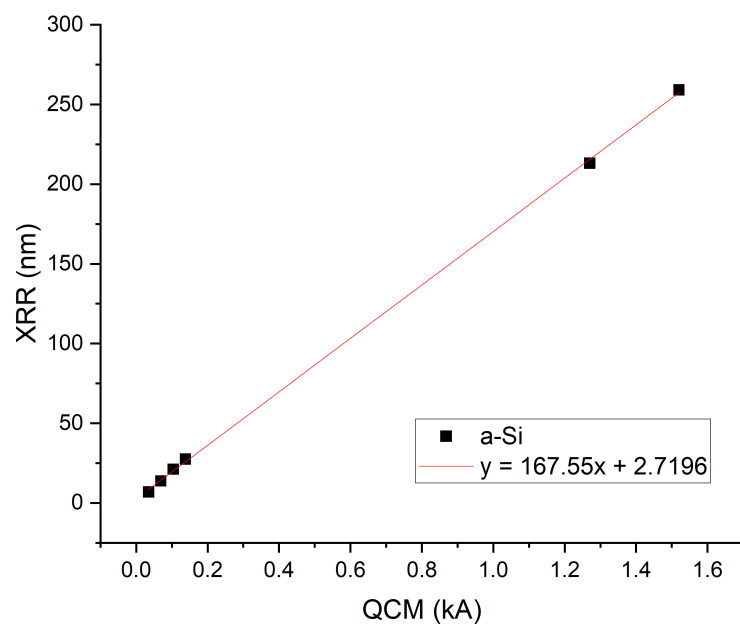


Figure 4.3: Linear regression of XRR and QCM thicknesses for a-Si thin films grown via e-beam evaporation.

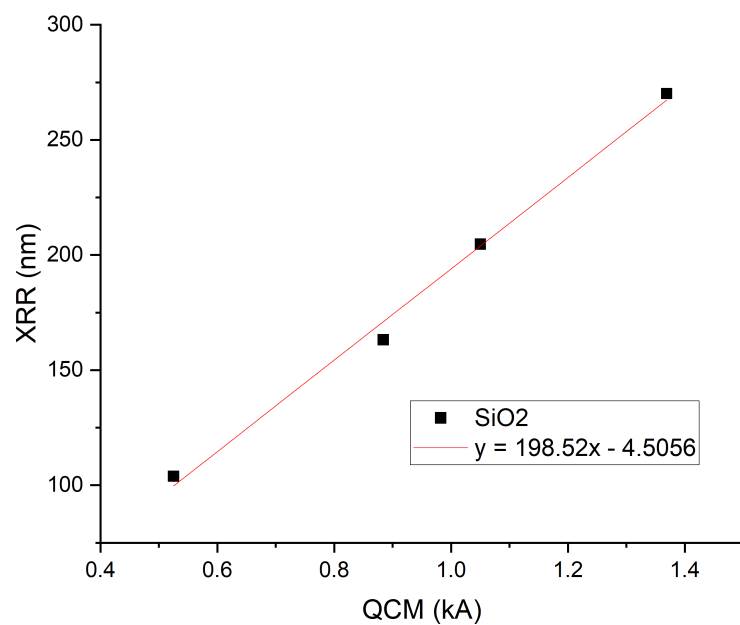


Figure 4.4: Linear regression of XRR and QCM thicknesses for SiO<sub>2</sub> thin films grown via e-beam evaporation.

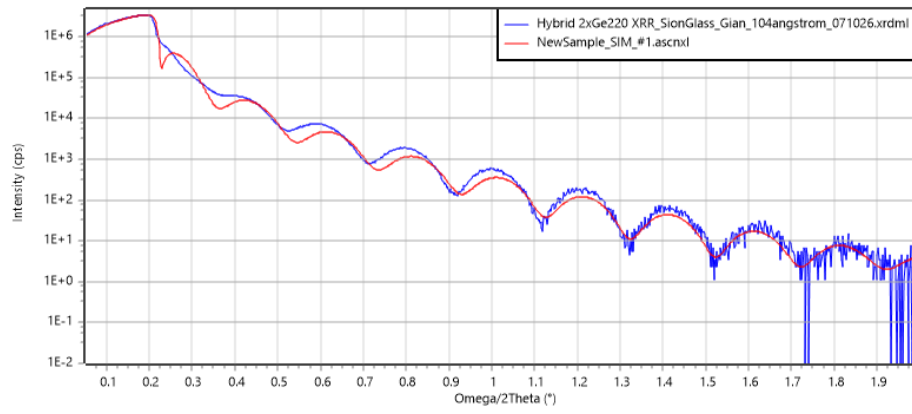


Figure 4.5: XRR curve fit to 21.20 nm a-Si thin film

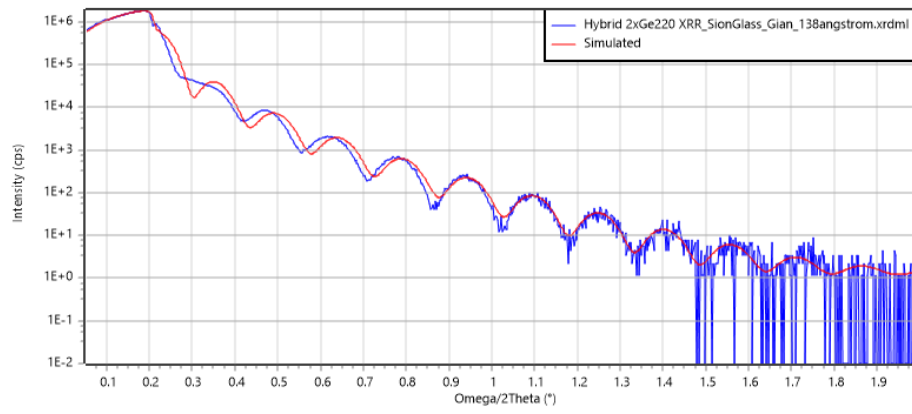


Figure 4.6: XRR curve fit to 27.50 nm a-Si thin film

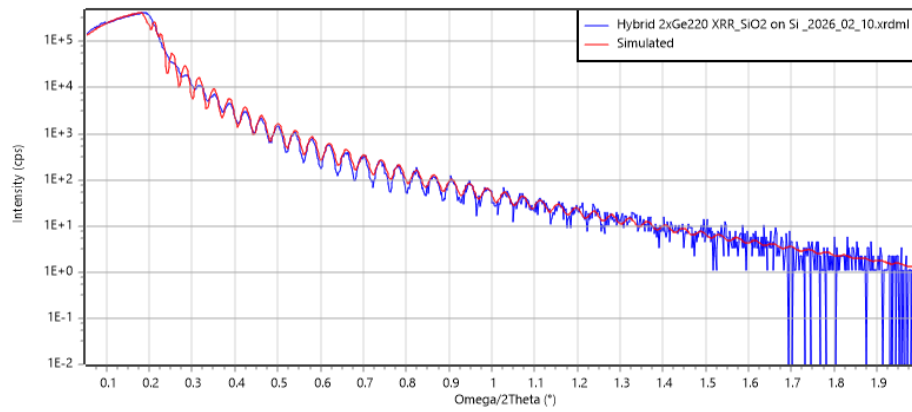


Figure 4.7: XRR curve fit to 103.9 nm SiO<sub>2</sub> thin film

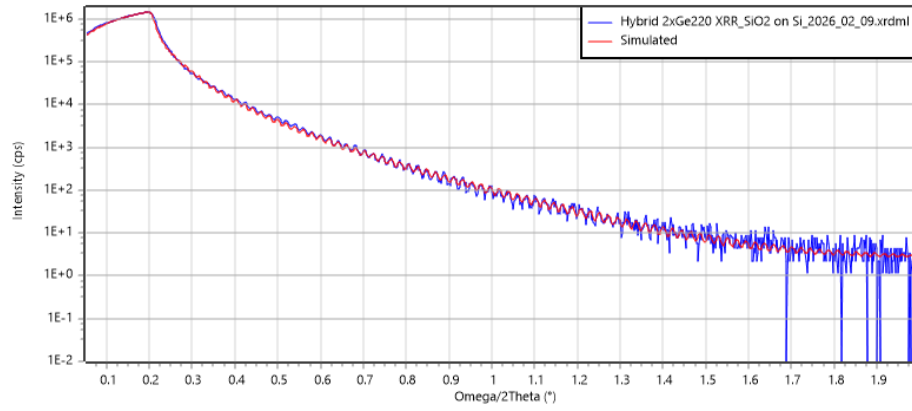


Figure 4.8: XRR curve fit to 204.7 nm SiO<sub>2</sub> thin film

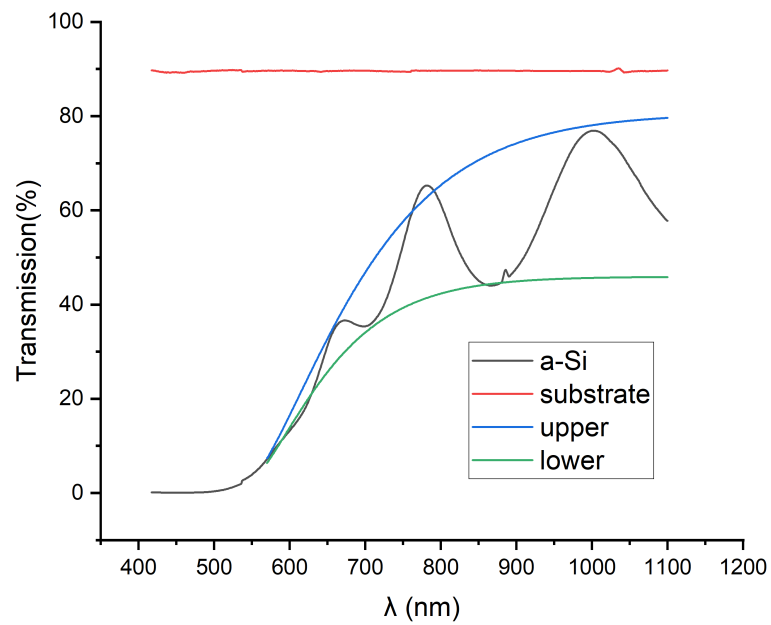


Figure 4.9: The transmission curves for the 600 nm a-Si thin film and the glass substrate together with the upper and lower envelopes for Swanepoel's method

## 4.2 Refractive index of a-Si thin films

Figure 4.9 shows the UV-Vis transmittance spectra of a 600 nm a-Si thin film deposited on a glass substrate together with the upper and lower envelopes as calculated using the Swanepoel method as described in section 2.6. The equations of the exponential functions fitted to the extrema points listed in Table 4.4 are

$$y = 80.612419 + 1.200883 \times 10^9 e^{-x/89.819343} - 12.00749 \times 10^9 e^{-x/89.821415} \quad (4.3)$$

for the upper envelope with  $R^2 = 0.9969$  and

$$y = 45.9178758 + 3.6028012 \times 10^{10} e^{-x/64.3969697} - 3.16015549 \times 10^{10} e^{-x/64.3973202} \quad (4.4)$$

for the lower envelope with  $R^2 = 0.9977$ . The equation for the refractive index of the a-Si thin film according to Sellmeier's equation fitted to the data points of the refractive indices obtained from Swanepoel's method is

$$n^2 = 14.84529 + \frac{7.06709 \times 10^{12} \lambda^2}{\lambda^2 + 2.12449 \times 10^{18}} + \frac{-10.41841 \lambda^2}{\lambda^2 + 190469.027}. \quad (4.5)$$

and the graph of the resulting refractive index versus wavelength is shown in Figure 4.10. The average thickness of the a-Si thin film according to the Swanepoel method is 653 nm.

The refractive index of the a-Si thin film is comparable to the literature values obtained by Swanepoel for a-Si, with values ranging from 3.0 to 3.2 across the relevant wavelengths. However, the refractive index does not decrease monotonically with increasing wavelength as expected for the material. This deviation from the expected behavior is unlikely to be anomalous dispersion and instead is probably caused by the few number of data points from Swanepoel's method used to fit the Sellmeier equation. This is supported by the difference in calculated thickness for the film using Swanepoel's method and the extrapolation using Equation 4.1. A larger number of oscillations and

| $\lambda$ (nm) | $T_{film}$ | $T_{sub}$ | $T_M$ | $T_m$ | $n_s$ | $N$  | $n_1$ | $d_1$ (nm) | $m$  | $d_2$ (nm) | $n_2$ |
|----------------|------------|-----------|-------|-------|-------|------|-------|------------|------|------------|-------|
| maxima         |            |           |       |       |       |      |       |            |      |            |       |
| 1002           | 76.9       | 86.3      | 78.1  | 45.7  | 1.62  | 4.76 | 3.04  | 698.1      | 3.47 | 659.4      | 3.07  |
| 782            | 65.3       | 88.2      | 62.9  | 41.4  | 1.61  | 4.45 | 2.93  | 422.4      | 4.28 | 666.8      | 3.00  |
| 655            | 33.5       | 89.5      | 34.3  | 26.7  | 1.61  | 5.34 | 3.23  | 564.0      | 5.64 | 608.1      | 3.01  |
| 590            | 11.3       | 89.7      | 13.3  | 11.3  | 1.61  | 6.00 | 3.43  |            |      |            |       |
| minima         |            |           |       |       |       |      |       |            |      |            |       |
| 871            | 44.1       | 86.9      | 72.3  | 44.5  | 1.61  | 4.59 | 2.98  | 737.9      | 3.91 | 657.6      | 3.00  |
| 709            | 36.1       | 89.6      | 49.0  | 35.2  | 1.61  | 4.38 | 2.91  | 426.7      | 4.68 | 670.8      | 2.99  |
| 613            | 16.4       | 89.6      | 21.5  | 17.7  | 1.61  | 5.34 | 3.23  | 281.5*     |      |            |       |
| 571            | 7.4        | 89.6      | 7.6   | 6.6   | 1.61  | 8.18 | 4.02  |            |      |            |       |
| $\bar{d}$      |            |           |       |       |       |      |       | 569.8      |      | 652.53     |       |

Table 4.4: Relevant values for Swanepoel's method of the a-Si thin film.\* The last  $d_1$  of 281.5 nm is excluded from further calculations due to its distance from the other thickness values

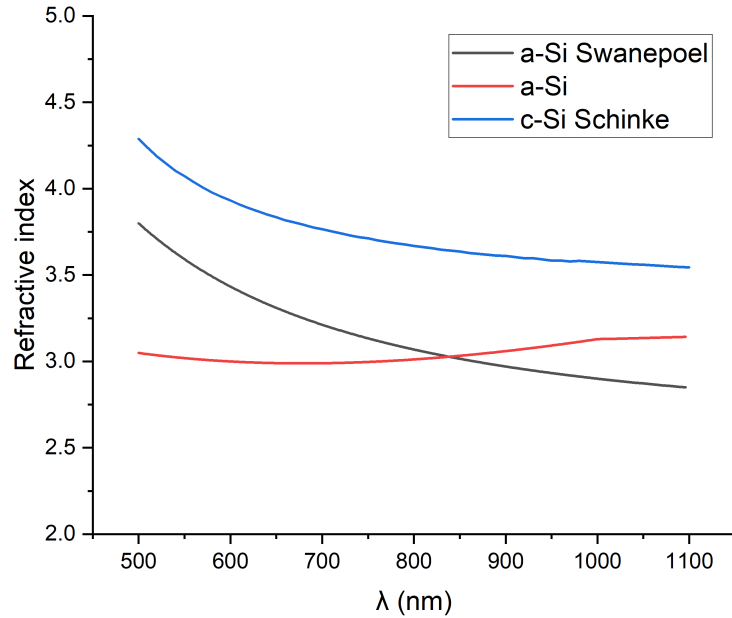


Figure 4.10: Refractive index of a-Si thin film from 500 nm to 1100 nm

data points would likely yield a more accurate Sellmeier equation that would exhibit the proper dispersion behavior across the wavelength range[40]. Furthermore, the a-Si thin film refractive index is much lower than that of crystalline silicon, which has a refractive index of 3.5 to 4.25 across the range of wavelengths as measured by Schinke[41]. This is likely due to the lower density and less ordered structure of the a-Si thin film compared to crystalline silicon, and supports the previous finding in section 4.1.

### 4.3 Refractive index of SiO<sub>2</sub> thin films

Figure 4.11 shows the reflectance spectra of a 990 nm SiO<sub>2</sub> thin film deposited on a Si substrate after deconvolution using a mirror. The extrema points used for the calculation of the refractive index of the film using Equation 2.9 are listed in Table 4.5 together with the corresponding refractive indices and the new wavelengths. Figure 4.12 shows the graph of the refractive index after fitting the data points to Sellmeier's equation, which is

$$n^2 = 14.84529 + \frac{7.06709 \times 10^{12} \lambda^2}{\lambda^2 + 2.12449 \times 10^{18}} + \frac{-10.41841 \lambda^2}{\lambda^2 + 190469.027}. \quad (4.6)$$

with  $R^2 = 0.998$ .

The refractive index of the SiO<sub>2</sub> thin film is comparable to the literature values obtained from Gao[42]. The slight increase in refractive index versus the literature values could be attributed to the stoichiometry of the SiO<sub>2</sub> thin film caused by a lack of reactive gas during the deposition process, leading to a higher refractive index closer to

| $\lambda_0$ (nm) | R     | $\lambda_1$ (nm) | $n_1$ | $\lambda_2$ (nm) | $n_2$ |
|------------------|-------|------------------|-------|------------------|-------|
| minima           |       |                  |       |                  |       |
| 530.0            | 0.052 | 587.5            | 1.50  | 676.3            | 1.50  |
| 645.0            | 0.040 | 733.8            | 1.50  |                  |       |
| 822.5            | 0.043 |                  |       |                  |       |
| maxima           |       |                  |       |                  |       |
| 577.5            | 0.154 | 648.8            | 1.47  | 765.0            | 1.48  |
| 720.0            | 0.140 | 836.3            | 1.48  |                  |       |
| 952.5            | 0.216 |                  |       |                  |       |

Table 4.5: Refractive indices and wavelengths for the SiO<sub>2</sub> thin film

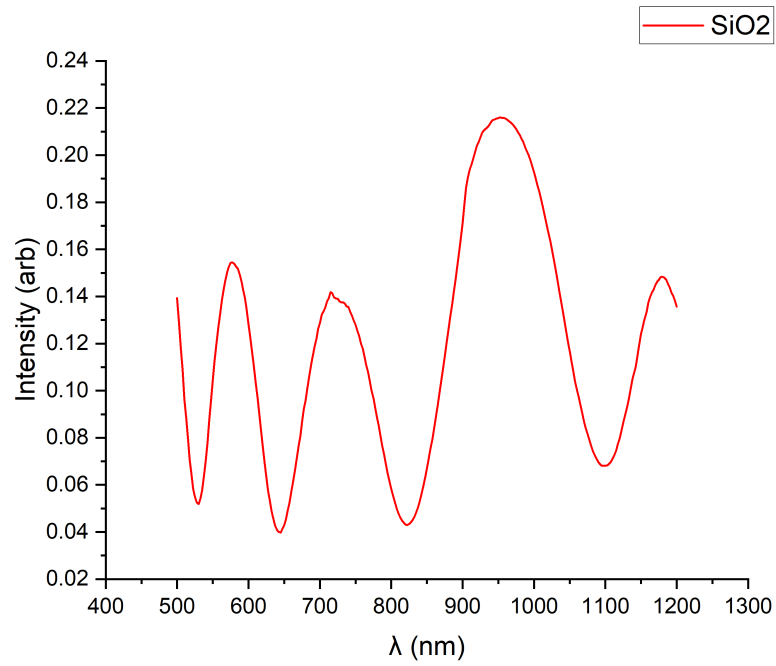


Figure 4.11: Deconvoluted reflectance spectra of 990 nm SiO<sub>2</sub> thin film

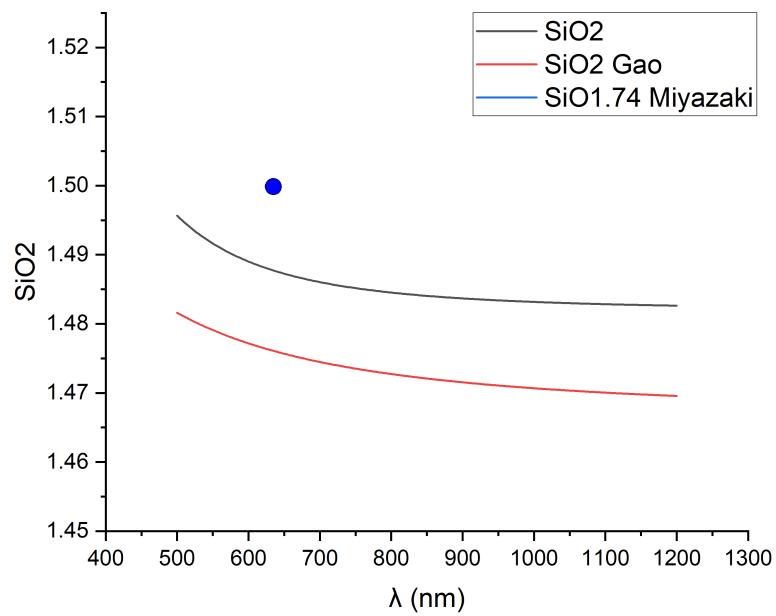


Figure 4.12: Refractive index of the SiO<sub>2</sub> film compared to Gao and Miyazaki

that of silicon. Miyazaki et al. deposited  $\text{SiO}_{1.74}$  thin films and found that the refractive index at 633 nm was 1.50, which is higher than the refractive index. The lower density of the  $\text{SiO}_2$  thin film compared to bulk  $\text{SiO}_2$  as measured by XRR previously may be caused by the increased porosity of the film or the decreased ratio of oxygen versus silicon.

#### 4.4 Reflectance of a-Si/SiO<sub>2</sub> antireflective coatings

Figure 4.13 shows the reflectance spectra of a-Si/SiO<sub>2</sub> antireflective coatings with layer thicknesses of 53 nm/14 nm/206 nm, 48 nm/19 nm/208 nm, and 49 nm/24 nm/251 nm for the SiO<sub>2</sub>/a-Si/SiO<sub>2</sub> layers respectively using the refractive indices obtained in the previous sections. The simulated reflectance spectra for the first ARC shows a value less than 1 % around 630 nm, whereas the simulation of the second ARC shows a minimum at 660 nm. The measured reflectance spectra for the ARCs show that the minimum value around 4 % for the first ARC at 660 nm and a minimum value of 2.5 % for the second ARC at 720 nm. Table 4.6 summarizes the relevant information of the ARCs being studied. The blank Si wafer exhibits a reflectivity ranging from 50 % to 75 % across the wavelength range of 450 nm to 1000 nm.

The layers deposited using electron beam deposition demonstrated a reduced value of reflectance compared to the bare wafer, proving their effectiveness as antireflective coatings. The mismatch in the minimum values obtained experimentally versus the simulation is due to the limitation of the experimental setup, which measures the re-

|           | 1st zero       |   | 2nd zero         |   |
|-----------|----------------|---|------------------|---|
|           | $\lambda$ (nm) | R | $\lambda_0$ (nm) | R |
| ARC 1 TMM |                |   |                  |   |
| ARC 1     |                |   |                  |   |
| ARC 2 TMM |                |   |                  |   |
| ARC 2     |                |   |                  |   |
| ARC 3 TMM |                |   |                  |   |
| ARC 3     |                |   |                  |   |

Table 4.6: Thickness, roughness and densities calculated from XRR curve fitting

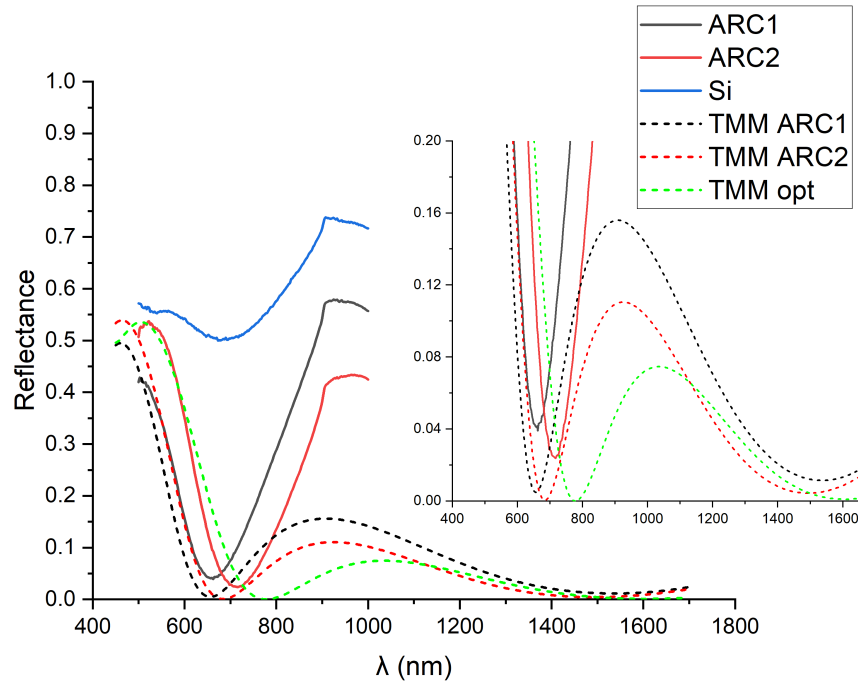


Figure 4.13: Reflectivities of ARCs with varying layer thicknesses simulated using the transfer matrix method and measured experimentally. The reflectivity of a bare Si wafer is included for comparison.

flectance of the sample relative to the mirror. More accurate reflectivity values would be obtained from absolute measurements which consider the total amount of light incident and reflected from the sample. The deviation of wavelengths at which the measured reflectance exhibit the minima from the simulated values can be attributed to the inaccuracy in measuring the refractive index of the thin films which were previously deposited, especially for a-Si.

# **CHAPTER 5**

## **CONCLUSION**

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### Gantt chart

[illegible]

| ITEM                  | DESCRIPTION                  | UNIT COST | QUANTITY | TOTAL      |
|-----------------------|------------------------------|-----------|----------|------------|
| Fabrication supplies  |                              |           |          |            |
| Acetone               | 4L (JTBaker)                 | 2,300.00  | 1 bottle | 2,300.00   |
| 38% Hydrochloric acid | 2.5L (JTBaker)               | 3,955.00  | 1 bottle | 3,955.00   |
| Photoresist           | 250ml (ma-P 1225)            | 37,200.00 | 1 bottle | 37,200.00  |
| Developer             | 2.5L (mr-D 526/S)            | 24,100.00 | 1 bottle | 24,100.00  |
| Si wafers             | Si(100), 2", undoped         | 11,342.50 | 2 pcs    | 22,685.00  |
| Others                |                              |           |          |            |
| Printing              |                              |           |          | 5,000.00   |
| Characterization      | Scanning electron microscopy |           |          | 10,000.00  |
| Total                 |                              |           |          | 105,240.00 |